

Shadows of Titan

to Rhea. She would be worried sick by now but a feeling in his stomach told him that even this was too far out of the doctor's purview.

Chapter 17

Their patrol was flawless. Every citizen they passed offered up their comtechs for pictures, offered bows, smiles, and thank-yous. Some even cheered. Their reports were clean and civilian sentiments were high. Nyx moved with Darius as an Apex golden pair, glowing and untouchable. They shared banter, easy and light, Darius cracking dry jokes, Nyx jabbing back. It felt comfortable.

But Nyx noticed something quickly, he barely let her use her energy. Any time her fingers twitched, any time a situation might have required even the smallest of her warps, he stepped in. Quick, efficient, but protective.

She didn't say anything about it; she wasn't even angry, just watching and wondering. By nightfall, he was quiet again. They stood along the outside of the dorms, the city lit blue and gold behind them, and he was watching her. Like he was trying to figure something out.

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He pushed off the wall with a smirk. “Come train with me.”

Nyx blinked, honestly surprised. “Are you sure?”

“Yeah.” His grin tugged deeper. “I think I understand how you work.”

She narrowed her eyes slightly. “Trying to get shown up again?”

“Again?” he scoffed. “Last time was a fluke.”

A soft laugh slipped from her lips, catching her slightly off-guard. “You’re impossible.”

He grinned like he had won something and started off to the newly reinforced Dominion Training Convergence. Inside the training hall, the arena lights shimmered and energy hummed through the gold beams and reinforced floor. The whole place had had an overhaul and was put back together better than ever, it seemed.

Nyx stepped onto the floor beside him, her body tight with anticipation. Her power itched beneath her skin, eager. Darius cracked his knuckles, flames flickering along his gauntlets.

“I’m not holding back,” he warned.

“Good,” she replied. “I’d be insulted if you did.”

Then he lunged, the heat exploded from his fist, fire snapping through the air. Nyx danced back, twisting around the blaze with ease, her body flowing like smoke. He struck again, faster, but she dodged again. Every hit he launched was a controlled inferno and every dodge she made was perfect.

“You’re fast,” Darius growled in frustration.

“And you’re predictable,” she laughed. He growled and charged again, harder. But when his gauntlets flared close, Nyx raised a hand, space shimmering around him before he vanished.

“Hey! What the hell?” he barked as soon as he reappeared on the other side of the arena.

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“Practising something new!” she called. Before he could recover, she warped him again, this time mid-air.

He blinked in, upside down, unleashing a burst of fire just to stabilise. The arena walls echoed with his laughter as she twisted his fire, bending it into beautiful arcs, spinning it like light across glass. Warp, flame, motion, and precision. They moved together in sync as she warped him around the arena, the spar turning wild as Darius released hotter and hotter fire.

Darius laughed loudly, clearly having a good time. “What else you got?” he called.

Nyx raised her hands, concentrating, her silver glow shifting to almost white. “You trust me?” she called back.

He looked taken aback. “Should I be scared?”

“Always!” She released her energy into him, the world around her pulsing violently, shockwaves shaking the ground beneath her as she rose. His body lit up immediately; his veins pulsed so bright they cast shadows around him. His flames grew concentrated with heat and his breath came out like a dragon's breath.

“What is this?” he whispered, stunned by his own reflection on the shimmered walls. He unleashed fire that was blinding, the heat causing Nyx to raise a dozen barriers, warping blasts into harmless spirals, protecting the arena, burning behind him like a comet trail. His speed drew her along as he tore through the limits of his own strength, leaving her free to dance behind him, correcting what he burned.

He finally slowed, dropping to one knee, breath heaving, steam and fire rising from his shoulders. She lowered herself down next to him, easing her energy down gently.

“That...” he rasped, looking up at her. “What was that?”

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She knelt slightly, her hand brushing his shoulder, unbothered by the flames. “I said I wanted to try something.”

They stared at each other, the space between them humming, his skin glowing like molten metal, his eyes boring into her.

“I told you I could keep up,” she murmured.

He exhaled a shaky laugh. “Show-off.” But he didn’t pull away. His hand lifted, fingertips ghosting over her cheek, searing but inviting. Her eyes fluttered; he leaned in, close enough to feel his breath on her lips.

“Nyx...” he breathed.

“DARIUS VALKYRIE AND OPERATIVE NYX. REPORT TO THE BRIEFING HALL IMMEDIATELY.”

The intercom shattered through the room like fragile glass. Darius’s eyes narrowed as he stood, muttering under his breath, the glow in his veins flaring to life again.

Nyx composed herself, fighting the frown that threatened her face.

Darius looked her over briefly as he adjusted his gauntlet. “You going to be okay?” he asked gruffly.

She nodded. “I’ll be fine.”

Darius held her gaze a moment longer, then turned without a word toward the exit, leading down a corridor and to the briefing halls, the walls becoming more opulent the further they went into the spire, making her feel small and exposed. She almost had to jog behind Darius

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to keep up, the flames still radiating from his shoulders and hair leaving a hot trail of air in his wake.

When they entered the briefing hall, she felt her spine go rigid. The lights had been dimmed, casting the space in sharp relief, Darius's flames almost outshining the moment.

Commander Voxx sat at the centre of the table, his wings folded partially behind him, strangely at attention even seated. To his right sat Dr. Vaelith, composed and clinical, her green eyes slightly widened, observing Darius's current state. Dominion Trainer Lynx Kairen lounged against the wall behind them, his Nullify-field humming just enough to make Nyx's skin crawl.

Flanking the other sides of them, like wolves waiting to pounce, were the others. Eira Solaris, cold and sharp, next to an even more agitated General King; Dr. Ekros sat at the end, red lenses and teal gloves gleaming unnaturally in the half-light, lounged to the side of King, twitching with barely restrained excitement.

She felt Darius stiffen beside her, but he said nothing as they saluted and came to attention. "Nyx. Valkyrie," Commander Voxx's voice rang out, clipped and even. "Step forward."

Nyx held her head high as they stepped closer to the table, now in the semi-circle of officials.

"We observed everything," Commander Voxx started.

Nyx's breath caught, but she didn't say anything.

"You two," Lynx cut in, "nearly set the arena on fire again. Did you think that wouldn't trip every alert in our systems?"

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“We monitor all training sessions,” Dr. Vaelith soothed. “But this wasn’t a simple surge. It was a new type of energy.” Her gaze shifted between Darius and Nyx. “A deep and possibly dangerous one.”

“This is unprecedented, to say the least!” Ekros piped in. “Synergy without physical contact. With that kind of output. It was almost...” He looked at her, amused. “Mythic.”

Nyx winced involuntarily at the word.

King scoffed from his seat. “It’s reckless. She could have caused him to spin out, or even melted the facility, again, from that little stunt.”

“She didn’t, though,” Darius said coldly, cutting over King. “I’m still standing, better than ever.”

Eira raised an eyebrow. “You are still on fire, Darius. That suggests otherwise.”

Before Darius could retort, Dr. Vaelith raised a hand like a scalpel. “We’re not here to squabble.”

Dr. Ekros jumped up, stepping down from the dais, hands clasped behind his back, like he was observing experiments. “There’s endless potential here. If properly channelled and directed.”

Nyx’s fingers twitched, but she kept them from forming a fist.

“I’d like to initiate a trial of guided synergy pairings,” Ekros said. “We will rotate Nyx through select Apexes to see stability and versatility.”

“No,” Darius said. The room stilled.

Ekros blinked rapidly, as if surprised by his audacity. “You haven’t even heard the pairings,” he sputtered.

“I don’t need to,” he snapped.

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“I’m not rotating,” Nyx spoke up. “I’m staying with Darius.”

Lynx chuckled darkly. “You think you get to choose?”

“I do when my energy could level the place,” she replied, tone cold.

Commander Voxx interjected smoothly, as if to calm the waters. “We are not forcing you. But you should hear the options.”

“General King, Solaris. Commander Voxx himself—” Ekros started excitedly.

“No.” Nyx cut him off.

Eira smirked, leaning back in her chair, clearly expecting a fallout.

“You go missing for almost two days,” General King snapped, the light flaring around him. “And now you’re back without a word expecting to make decisions about this?”

Nyx opened her mouth to defend herself, but Darius beat her to it. “That was a personal, familial matter. It’s been handled.”

The tension in the room rose like a heatwave, but no one challenged him, letting her know that he had kept his word and hadn’t told anyone.

Dr. Vaelith added, “Their readings, though high, are stable.” She concurred, holding eye contact with Darius for an extra beat before turning to Ekros.

Ekros in turn looked disappointed, but smiled. “Fine. Fine. No reassignment. But we must study this!”

Nyx felt her heart pounding in her ribs. She fought the panic rising in her chest.

“Then let’s schedule a Tier evaluation,” Darius said. Nyx could feel the heat fluctuating around him, his temper barely in check.

Commander Voxx’s wings twitched faintly. “That will do then. Dismissed.”

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Nyx turned on her heel and stalked out next to Darius. As soon as the doors swung shut behind them, she exhaled hard.

“That could’ve gone worse,” Darius said.

Nyx didn’t answer. She could still feel the pressure of Ekros’s stare, knowing what his plan was and that he would stop at nothing to own her. Her fingers twitched and she fought the ringing in her ears.

Darius was at her side, one burning hand on her shoulder, grounding her. He had a concerned look on his face, but he didn’t say anything. He guided her silently back through the hallways, their steps quiet, the lights dim, the building even feeling claustrophobic in some places.

Darius swiped open his door, ushered her inside, and let out a low sigh. “We need to talk.”

He walked her over to a low table and pulled a chair out with his foot, sitting her down gently. As he settled in the opposite chair, he studied her, saying nothing, waiting.

Nyx stared at her hands, thoughts flickering in and out of her mind. “So they just want to use us?” she asked finally.

“Yeah,” Darius muttered, dragging a hand through his hair. “And they’re pretty damned excited about it.”

She narrowed her eyes at him. “That doesn’t bother you?” she asked.

He leaned back, eyes tracing the seams in the ceiling. “It does. But what’s the alternative? Hmm, Nyx? Besides, if they don’t do it, someone else will. And we won’t get a choice then.” He sighed heavily, rolling his shoulders. “Just the price of having a strong mutation. The attention. The pressure.”

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She sighed and leaned back as well, her voice softer now. “I just don’t want to be their weapon.”

He gave her a half-smile. “Then be your own weapon.”

She raised an eyebrow, curiosity piqued. “What are you talking about?”

His smile widened and he turned to her, sitting up. “I have an idea. But you’re going to need to change into something fireproof.”

She blinked back at him, a thrill flashing through her gut. She nodded and headed to her room, tearing through storage until she found some AAN-issued fire-resistant gear. Just to be sure, she sent Darius a picture on her comtech to make sure. Seconds later a knock rang out.

Darius stood there, already geared up in an alternate Apex ops suit. Sleek, black, and ember-red, layered with reactive plating and trimmed with gold veins that pulsed faintly with his molten glow. His gauntlets were also different, more rugged and heavier-looking. There wasn’t an AAN insignia in sight.

He was holding a matching women’s set for her. She didn’t ask how or why he had it; she just changed quickly. Once she stepped out, Darius gave her a slow once-over before handing her his comtech, which was already set to a location. “Think you can warp us here?”

She nodded, touched his shoulder without a word, and away they went. They landed beneath Titan’s surface, in the heart of the Deepforge Maw, and from the sounds of it, right under the Spineheart Market. The Pulse Duels. An illegal, underground duelling arena that pulsed with heat, neon, and the chaos of the Luminal underground scene. The crowd was wild, Dregs and Luminals alike crammed into the coliseum's edge, every face turned toward the centre stage where fire and energy exploded violently.

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Above it all stood the Ash King AI, his part-humanoid, part-holographic tech body perched cockily atop a towering obsidian speaker, its electric eyes scanning the crowd, voice booming through the structure like a roar.

“This,” Darius said, raising his voice just over the crowd, “is how we get you some energy.”

Nyx turned to him, confused. “What?”

He grinned. “The duel ring. We enter, we fight, we win. Winners get to drain the energy from the losers.”

Her instincts flared in warning, but excitement quickly took over. She nodded and they inched closer to see two Dreg mutants, one with electro-bone projections, the other with elastic limbs and acidic blood. Their battle was vicious, unrestrained, the arena creaking and shifting under the strain. The winner was rewarded with an energy-extractor, draining the allotted amount out of the loser. But it was the next rounds that made her clench her fists.

Two Luminal twins, Team Ruin. They were blonde, slick, and arrogant with insane synergy. One, Slick, generated thick, flammable oil from his pores, creating slick fields and fuel-laced traps. The other, Flux, detonated them with energy-charged blasts. Controlled combustion on anything and everything. Their competitors hadn’t stood a chance. They had already taken down two teams, draining them brutally at the end, laughing and joking as the medics pulled them off the bodies of the losers.

Nyx hated them, and bile rose to her throat as she saw the mangled and ashy bodies being carted away below. The Ash King’s voice split through the colosseum: “Next in the ring... is Team X versus... Team Ruin!”

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The crowd erupted and murmurs spread like wildfire as the crowd made way for Nyx and Darius to make their way through. If anyone recognised them, no one said anything. With this gear, they looked like any other hungry pair of Luminals.

As the dome sealed above them, Slick and Flux grinned wickedly, hooting at Nyx, clearly trying to intimidate her. Darius leaned in close. “This isn’t the best matchup. It’s going to be a firepower test and this place isn’t built like a training arena. We have to keep it contained.”

Nyx nodded, thinking fast. “I won’t warp either. Too noticeable.”

He nodded. “Maybe just Dark Transformation and...” He chewed his lip, thinking.

“I can focus your heat,” she said assuredly, thinking back to the arena. “I can control directly where it goes. Minimise the damage.”

He looked sceptical. “If this goes wrong...”

“I’ve got it!” She flicked him on the shoulder with a smile.

They took positions, each at the corners of the diamond-shaped starting formation. The arena went almost silent as they crouched, waiting.

As soon as the buzzer sounded, chaos erupted. Slick darted forward, covering everything he touched in flammable oil. He lunged at Nyx and she bent the space beneath her, transmuting the ground into a hard barrier that rippled upward to deflect the spray. Darius launched himself forward, slamming into Slick mid-air, driving a flaming gauntlet straight into his chest. The oil ignited instantly and Slick screamed.

“Well, it seems Slick is not fireproof!” the Ash King’s mocking voice rang out overhead.

Flux roared and charged, explosive charges crackling in his hands. Nyx raised barriers in sequence, forcing him to detonate early. She absorbed the right blast into her palms, pain flaring

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as the energy coursed through her. She hurled it back, slamming Flux into the wall with a blast that left craters.

Darius caught her waist and slung her skyward. Nyx twisted mid-air as Darius launched a full-powered blast from below, twin streams of molten energy and fire arcing upward. Nyx bent the stream mid-flight, redirecting the searing magma downward straight at the twins, one rushing to cover the other.

The crowd's roar drowned their screams. Team Ruin looked like their name. Their bodies writhing on the floor, scorched and stunned, coughing from the residual vapour of their own firepower turned against them. Darius grabbed Nyx as she landed, the ground shaking slightly from the impact.

It was hardly fair, she mused, as the Ash King's voice rang over the arena with theatrical glee. "Oooh, the long-running champs are down!! Wasn't that so threxed?! All hail the winner!! Team X!"

The crowd roared, the neon lights flashed, and the heat from the scorched floor still radiated around them. She felt sick; she and Darius were leagues above this place, even the Luminals stood no chance.

The Ash King, voice like glass grinding against steel, rang over the mic. "So, winners... What's it gonna be? Hmmm? How will you take what's yours? Hm???"

Nyx blinked, unsure, and Darius gave her a serious look as he moved in closer. In his hand was a sleek extractor. She barely had time to process before he bent down and swiftly jammed his into the neck of semi-conscious Slick, and then into his own. The effect was instantaneous from the injection point. His veins pulsed with molten light, power flooding through him like a violent surge.

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Nyx quickly followed suit, slamming the extractor into Flux's neck then into her own.

Heat.

It tore through her like liquid electricity, blurring her vision, softening and sharpening everything at once. The crowd's roar of approval became static in her ears.

She laughed, hearing the sound of Darius's laugh echoing somewhere overhead.

"Again!" she heard herself yell, the sensation overwhelming her.

Somewhere in the back of her mind, reason whispered that the twins looked bad. Really bad. That this was too far, but the Ash King was already descending from his towering throne of speakers and wires, clad in a sequined half-suit that glittered with illegal tech and rare gems. His voice, warbled and animated behind the shifting glass of his face, cut through the haze.

"They won..." he sing-songed, "Full energy rights! Drain them dry! DRY! DRY! **DRY!**"

The chant exploded around the colosseum. "Drain them dry! DRY! DRY! **DRY!**"

Nyx swayed, trying to find Darius in the swirling haze. Her vision stuttered, filled with flashing lights and the pulsing heat of his body somewhere in front of her. It was almost unbearable, radiant, molten, and dangerous.

"One of Team X is hesitating.....oooooh, seems like only one member of this team carries the weight!" the Ash King's taunt echoed.

Nyx didn't have time to react.

She felt Darius's arm wrap around her waist as he slammed the extractor into her neck.

She gasped as she felt her body surge, her knees almost buckled under her, and suddenly everything around her became crystal clear. Darius's face hovered inches from hers, his molten

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eyes wild, his strong jaw clenched tight. It was normally clean-shaven, but he had a brush of a shadow now.

The crowd screamed as the Ash King raised his hands, spinning like a twisted dancing god. “Unless they’re going to wreck right here on the floor! I say, let’s **GET THIS PARTY....STAAARRRTTTEEDDD!**”

The arena peeled open, the crowd surging down. A tunnel opened beneath them, leading into a subterranean afterspace. A bright orange sign blinked over the entrance: **PURE VEIN**. A throbbing, pulsing hive of dark-light, open synergy cages, spore drinks, and heat-drenched bodies.

Nyx stumbled as they were herded through, the Ash King’s holographic face narrowing, eyes tracking them carefully.

She felt everything, every vibration in the floor, every heartbeat, every fleeting glance she took at Darius. She clung to his arm, too disoriented to speak; she could only follow the flow of slick bodies.

They finally reached the sanctuary of their assigned pod, a dark velvet capsule with screens and low music. As he sat, she climbed onto his lap, wrapping herself around him, savouring the burning heat. “I don’t think we should be here,” she whispered against his ear, a small hiccup catching in her throat.

Darius chuckled under her, deep and warm. He lifted her chin gently. “I agree. Wanna get out of here?”

She giggled deliriously, her control fraying at the edges. Her mind screamed at her to focus, but her thoughts refused to pull it together. “Where to, Cap?” another unseemly hiccup.

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“Let's go home,” he murmured. Then he scooped her up without hesitating, cradling her like she weighed nothing, and strode out of their pod and into the club.

She couldn't see where they were going. All she could do was breathe him in. He smelled like smoke and something metallic and sweet, the heat from his body thrumming through her bones as she clung on to his massive biceps.

He ducked into a polished obsidian and gold bathroom. “We're alone,” he whispered in her ear. “I suggest you warp us out of here. If you can.”

Nyx giggled, pressing her face to the welcoming heat of his neck. “Anything for you.”

It took all her concentration. Home. She pushed dizzy thoughts of Vexal away and focused on Darius, clutching him tightly.

The world shattered and they reappeared with a hard thud in the hallway between their rooms, the quiet of the Apex dormitories a relief.

Nyx laughed loudly, breathless. Darius did too, his chest rising and falling as he carried her into his room and lowered them both onto the couch.

He looked at her for a long moment, his molten eyes intense, hair tousled over his face. “Did you have fun?” he asked finally.

She nodded, trying to hold her giggles in, grinning wide.

“Well...” he exhaled slowly. “I hate to break the mood, but we still need to talk. Buuuut...” he drawled with a lopsided grin at her pout. “I have something that might make it better.”

He stood up, gently lifting her from his lap. The moment he stepped away, Nyx felt the absence of his warmth like a cold slap. She hated how much she missed it. *Pull it together*, she scolded herself silently.

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Darius returned from his closet holding a slender black bottle etched with glowing red script. He dropped back onto the couch and pulled her effortlessly back into his lap. “This,” he said, tilting the bottle, “is pure Forgedeeep tradition. Reserved for victories, promotions, and in our case, special celebrations.”

Before Nyx could stop herself she reached up and touched his face, surprised by how smooth his skin felt under her fingers. “Then let’s celebrate,” she said, trying to hold back a giggle.

Darius tilted her head back and poured some of the shimmering liquid down her throat. It burned like fire and her body instantly lit up in a rush of heat, a buzzing sensation leaving her feeling weightless. She melted back into his chest, her body boneless and buzzing, her mind a jumble of thoughts.

She watched him take a deep drink, his body shuddering slightly as he set the bottle aside. The silence stretched as he idly traced circles along her arm, sending little electric jolts down her spine. She chewed her lip, her thoughts spinning, her mind trying to formulate a proper sentence.

“I’m Myth,” she blurted out, surprising herself.

She felt his breath hitch, but he didn’t say anything, just waited for her to continue.

“What I mean is my name is Myth. I don’t remember my childhood,” she continued quietly. “Or really anything much before the last few years. My mutation... I know I scare people. So I’ve just stayed... small.”

Her voice faltered. She hadn’t realised a tear had slipped free until Darius’s thumb brushed it gently from her cheek.

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“All I know is,” she continued, “the more energy I use, the more I have to replace. And that’s always been tricky. I can do a lot with my mutation, but I don’t. Because... well, you’ve seen what can happen.”

He was quiet for a long moment. Then, his voice low and careful, he asked, “Were you an Apex before this?”

She shook her head. “Mutations like mine... they’re considered too unstable. Too risky.”

Darius gave a faint laugh. “Yeah. Tell me about it. I spent half my life being mocked for being half-Ashdog. My mother... she synergised with one during a resonance surge. People called me dregtaint, hollowspawn, mutt.”

Her heart twisted at the pain still in his voice.

“And then,” he continued, “when I tried out for the Apex Corps, suddenly I was ‘exceptional.’ A symbol or something. Funny how fast people change their tune.”

Their eyes met, the rawness in his expression mirroring her own. He gave her a crooked smile, his canines flashing in the dim light. “But hey. Tonight’s a win. We found something that works. That and synergising should have you set.”

He lifted the bottle again and touched it to her lips. She drank it deeper this time, tilting her head back as the heat licked down her sternum.

“I have a question,” she asked suddenly, emboldened by the heated haze creeping through her brain. “What exactly is synergy?”

Darius coughed mid-swig, choking the liquid down, lowering the bottle slowly. His grin turned almost sheepish and she could see red creeping up his neck.

“Synergy... it’s when two... or more... mutations resonate together. Physically. It can amplify power, stabilise erratic mutations, or create entirely new effects. There’s synergising for

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combat reasons, for psych reasons, emotional reasons. The stronger the bond, the stronger the result, though.” He scratched the back of his neck. “Emotional synergy’s the rarest. Most unstable as well. And physical synergy is the easiest for obvious reasons and most likely to produce... off-spring.”

Her cheeks flushed, her stomach flipping. “Oh... So... have you synergised with a lot of people?”

He looked at her again, his voice dipping lower as he leaned in closer. “A few. Most were tactical or for research. What about you, Myth?”

Her name sounded so different coming from his mouth; she liked it. “One,” she said, fighting a hiccup.

Darius whistled low, leaning back. “No wonder it’s hard for you to maintain energy, especially with a mutation like yours.”

Myth didn’t speak at first; she could feel her chest rising and falling too quickly, her lungs straining under the weight of something she couldn’t name. She shook her head and pulled her knees to her chest, her fingers digging into the sticky fabric. “I’m scared. Of absorbing someone accidentally.”

Darius's hand moved gently to her hair, brushing a strand behind her ear. “Have you ever...?” His voice was careful.

She nodded slowly, shame and guilt tightening around her throat. “I didn’t mean to. Well, the first time I did, but—” Her voice faltered.

Darius’s arms wrapped tightly around her, his heat cocooning her like armour. “Hey, hey. You’re okay. I’m here now.”

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Tears came before she could stop them. Silent, hot sobs wracking her body, her brain buzzing with emotions.. She wasn't even sure why she was crying. "Sometimes," she said, breathing deeply, "it's just a lot."

He gave her a smile, brushing her tears with his thumb. "You're not supposed to do it alone. That's why you've got a partner."

Her laugh was soft, but it felt good. "You're right," she sighed.

"Of course I'm right," Darius said with a grin, puffing out his chest, jutting his chin in a very King-like manner. That got a hard laugh out of her; she felt her eyes brimming with a different type of tears.

He kept brushing her hair with his hand, his molten gaze locked on her, as if he was studying her. Myth could feel the heat rise to her cheeks again; she cleared her throat and glanced down at herself. "We need to shower."

He blinked. "Huh?"

"We're sitting here covered in Slick and Flux."

Darius groaned. "Ugh. You're right. There's enough Flux inside you, you don't need him on you too."

She doubled over laughing, half-falling off his lap. Darius laughed so hard tears streamed down his face. "Careful," he wheezed, not offering to help her from her half-sprawled spot, "we'll make it a foursome if we're not careful."

She gasped in mock horror. "Nooooooo!"

Still laughing, Darius lifted her easily in his arms, the world tilting just a little too much for comfort. She didn't know if it was her or him, but she clung to him, burying her face into his shoulder as he carried her into the bathroom.

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His bathroom was twice the size of hers, lined with obsidian tiles that shimmered with gold veins, illuminated by the light that refracted through the cracks.

Darius walked straight into the showers, clothes and all. Water struck his skin and immediately hissed into vapour, rolling into steam that shone with prismatic hues. The air rolled around them like a living thing as he set her down gently, his hand lingering a second on her waist.

“Oh wow,” she breathed, lifting her hands into the mist. Rainbow particles sparkled across her skin where freckles of light peeked through her dark body.

She stripped before her brain could tell her better. Her reflection in the glass shimmered and danced in the steam, light reflecting back at her in a rainbow dazzle.

She turned to Darius, but his suit was already gone, steam rolling off his body in thick trails. He stood still, haloed in light, broad shoulders glistening under the spray of the water. Magma lines pulsed along his arms and chest like cracks embedded in rock.

She reached for him, brushing her fingers along the thick scars across his ribs, then up to the vivid Magma trail that split his right bicep. She felt his body tremble under touch, but he didn't stop her.

Instead, he poured warm and sweet-smelling soap across her shoulders and hair. He worked the soap through her hair while his fingers massaged in soft, rhythmic circles. She bit back a groan at the sensation, her eyes rolling back slightly. His hands moved slowly and firmly from her hair to her neck, down her back, then her arms. Every motion gentle for such a giant man.

She returned the favour where she could, washing his chest, arms, abdomen. It gave her an excuse to run her fingers over his strong, muscular body, to feel it quiver under her touch.

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Her mind was swirling, the heat and haze making it hard to tell what was real and what was residual sensation. She swayed slightly on her feet, reaching out instinctively for balance, her hands meeting Darius's chest. His arms came around her without hesitation, steady and strong, anchoring her.

He waved a hand, turning the water off with a subtle flick and helping her out of the shower. He wrapped a thick towel around her, soft and massive, swallowing her body in warmth before he scooped her up. His body was already dry, only the tips of his hair dripping, curling with steam.

Back in his room, he laid her gently on the bed. She had barely noticed him moving, lost somewhere between the pulsing in her veins and hazy thoughts. Darius flopped down beside her, bottle in hand, stretching his long frame out beside her.

She tried not to gawk. Almost seven feet of sculpted muscle sprawled out next to her, skin still glistening faintly. Her eyes dragged across him before she could stop them, finally landing on his face, where a wicked grin spread as he flexed lazily. "Like what you see, pretty lady?"

Her cheeks flared hot. She grabbed the bottle from him in mock annoyance and took a burning swig, coughing slightly as it lit her up from the inside. Her vision blurred and the room tilted, the room turning liquid and soft at the edges.

Darius chuckled. "Alright, gimme some." He took a deep drink, then set the bottle on the side table before flipping on the embedded, wall-sized screen. The low hum of a broadcast flickered to life; the dim visuals of some moody, off-world drama played, painting the room a soft colour.

Shadows of Titan

He stared at the screen, his brows furrowed faintly. She could tell his focus was somewhere else entirely. “Care to share?” she teased.

He glanced at her, pausing before he let out a long breath. “Why... *did* you join the Apex Corps?”

The question took her by surprise and she exhaled slowly. “Because I needed to.”

His jaw tensed like he expected a cop-out, and looked like he was going to turn back to the screen.

She caught his face gently, guiding him back. “The first reason I needed to,” she began, “was because I had to do something about my mutation. I needed to find a place for me, somewhere or someone that wanted me, or be voided.” She dropped her hands, looking away. It slipped out before she could stop it. It wasn’t a lie, though. Dregs weren’t considered people by Apex standards, and the way things stood after her little debacle with Vexal...

She didn’t have time to spiral far before Darius was behind her, his warm body curling around her. He hugged her tight, pulling her flush against his chest as he lay back on the pillow. A long silence passed between them before he spoke quietly. “My mother, after they found out what happened, was outcast. A Dreg. Because of me. So I know how it feels.”

She turned to look up at him, the vulnerability in his voice twisting something deep in her chest.

“But guess what?” he said, clearing his throat, giving her a lopsided grin.

“What?” she replied softly, playing along.

“That’s what partners are for.” he sing-songed.

She laughed, relaxing into his hold, her head relaxing against his shoulder. She closed her eyes and tried to focus, but she couldn’t think through the haze.

Shadows of Titan

“Speaking of,” he murmured, brushing a strand of hair away. “How do you feel?”

“I... I don’t know,” she said honestly.

He exhaled, gently turning her face to him more fully. “You need to start telling me these things, okay?” His voice was low but firm.

She nodded without meeting his gaze. “Maybe it’s that stuff,” she mumbled, motioning vaguely toward the bottle on the table. “And I did have Slick, after all.”

He snorted. “They had a good combination of energy, sure. But honestly? Separately they were weak. I way overestimated them. Their energy did have a nice buzz to it, though.”

She tilted her head. “Is everyone’s energy different?”

“Oh, yeah,” he said, leaning back slightly. “That’s the danger of synergising with volatile mutations. You can get pulled into something you weren’t ready for. Then you spin out into nothing.”

She was quiet for a moment, her voice finally coming out small. “Have you ever spun out?”

He shook his head. “No. But I knew someone who did.” His face darkened briefly. “They just couldn’t stay away from each other.”

She didn’t press; whoever it was, she didn’t want to bring the mood down.

“So how did you synergise before me?” he asked suddenly, catching her off-guard.

She hesitated, a memory of Vexal flashing through her mind. She pushed it down and tried to focus on the important information. “I... well, it sort of just happened,” she said, rolling onto her stomach, her voice slightly muffled against the blanket. “Kind of how I first pulled energy from you. I didn’t plan it. Just needed it and they had a surplus of it.”

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Darius nodded, thoughtful. “Do you know if they had any aftereffects from your energy or mutation?”

She shrugged. “Honestly? I have no idea. They never said anything and just... left after.”

His frown flickered briefly before he quickly replaced it with a smile. “Well, I’m happy to report no negative effects here.”

She laughed, and he settled beside her. His gaze softened as he leaned close, brushing her face gently.

“It’ll be okay,” he whispered against her lips.

The kiss started soft, but the hunger and aching between them suddenly took over. She moved to straddle him, but he caught her wrist with a low growl and rolled her underneath him in one fluid motion.

His mouth claimed hers, deep, urgent, and unrelenting. His energy flowed into her, a molten rush that coursed through her body like a wildfire. Her back arched involuntarily, mouth parting in a gasp. He took advantage of the moment, pulling her tighter against him, his body solid and searing. Her energy flared in response, a pulse of silver and amethyst energy wrapping around his flames.

The temperature shifted wildly, the cooling system kicking into overdrive as his heat surged, flooding the room with cold air. She tucked herself smaller beneath him to escape the cold, her mind thick and hazy. Every nerve in her body vibrated as he trailed fire down her neck, his lips leaving burning kisses that made her breath catch.

The air felt heavy and electrified, and frost crept up the walls, icicles spider-webbing across the floor as her energy warped the space around them. His energy burst into white-blue

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flames, flickering with streaks of violet lightning. His eyes widened in shock, his breath shuddering.

She reached for him instinctively, her own energy responding in a rush.

He sat up slowly, pulling her into his lap, her knees sliding on either side of him. His forehead pressed against hers, both trembling, breathing hot and uneven.

“Is this too much?” he asked, his voice hoarse, heat coiling around every syllable.

She shook her head vehemently, delirious and breathless. “No. Don’t stop. Please don’t stop.”

His hips surged forward, plunging his rock-hard length deep into her, letting all his energy pour into her most intimate places. Her body seared and she cried out softly, the sensation almost too much as every cell felt ablaze with fire.

Purple and blue swirled like galaxies, pulsing in rhythmic waves around them as their bodies moved together. She trembled as her powers flared, warping time and light, the air shimmering with unnatural geometry. Darius groaned against her skin, his old scars glowing bright then fading into smooth flesh as her energy poured into his body uninhibited.

His fire consumed her in a cocoon of light as he gently rocked in and out of her, her eyes seeing stars as she clung to him. His fingers wove through her hair gently as he let out a guttural sound as heat rushed over her head. Her body soaked in every touch, every pulse, begging and welcoming every part of him.

Their bodies reached a fervour, sending shockwaves exploding outward, pure incandescent power that radiated out of them in halos of light, bathing the room in an electric colour. Everything seemed to freeze around her as her body reached its crescendo, her energy surging around his body.

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She collapsed against him, her chest heaving, her hair wild and damp against his skin as the light slowly faded. His body trembled slightly through the aftershocks, his body steaming, but his arm stayed wrapped around her like a vice. He pressed his lips into her hair, taking a deep breath. “Are you okay?” he asked, his voice still rough.

She nodded into his chest, unable to form words yet, smiling faintly as her body felt boneless against him. Her mind buzzed happily, warm and comfortable against him, finally catching her breath as her eyes slid closed. She tried to stop herself, but it was too late. She fell fast asleep, and for the first time in her life, she had good dreams.

Chapter 18

Commander Thallion Voxx was struggling to maintain his composure. He had left his command post in Sector 9 to fly back to Helion to personally assist a team of panicked techs. There had been an energy output from Valkyrie's room, and it had surged to near cataclysmic-level intensity. Sensor arrays were failing to read anything clearly, fried by overlapping flares of energy so intense they bent telemetry into static. At first, he'd planned to march in there and rip the man to pieces.

But then he saw the footage. Myth or rather, Nyx, he reminded himself grimly, had entered Darius's quarters earlier. Then there had been nothing for hours, and then an energy displacement signature in the hallway outside their rooms where they had reappeared. Darius had been carrying her and stumbling around.

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That mutation of hers always grated on him; it was reckless and annoying, and if you didn't know exactly what to look for, it could completely catch you off-guard. He hated surprises.

He dismissed the techs and returned to his private suite in the Apex Spire, where he could finally be alone. He shed his uniform with clinical precision and inspected his wings. They hadn't been fully deployed in months. He carefully flexed them open, all six glistening under the cold white light; the middle pair shook fragilely, and he flinched.

"Control," he breathed to himself. He carefully tucked them away and slipped into his night-suit and cloak before taking off into the night. He flew low and hard, keeping under the Aether Wards. The Undercity reeked of rot, more than usual, a signature of Dryst's territory.

The acid wind licked at the edges of his cloak, but never touched his skin. His energy signature was already tuned to reject corrosion; he was a Commander, after all.

He landed hard enough to shake the ground. There were few ways to Dryst's lair; as it was stitched into the hollow bones of an old reactor, it hung off the edge of the Undercity, the walls pulsing with bio-reactive fluid, veins of toxins and entropy.

Varian was already waiting, his teal-gloved hands laced behind his back. The old doctor looked up, amusement glinting through his red frames.

"You're late," Dr. Ekros said.

"No," Thal corrected, his voice cutting through the dense, chemical air. "There have been some developments."

His long cloak whispered behind him as he stalked around the cluttered lab, acid steam curling at the edges of his boots. He made his way to the sunken centre of the reactor, where Fane Dryst sat immobile in his grotesquely modified assist chair. Half medical necessity, half

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whatever weird things the doctor had done to it, the man looked like forgotten trash. Rotting and rot-covered, Thal stood over him, scrutinising his ruined body.

“Well? What’s the report?” Thal asked, turning away to Varian and the cluster of active screens hovering beside him.

Varian stumbled through a few panels hurriedly. The footage revealed past synergy trials: Thal paired with various Dreg variants. Most ended in disaster, with mutated bodies swollen with unstable energy, limbs splitting at the seams. Unthinking monsters made docile only by direct neural implants. Perfect weapons with no soul.

Thal scoffed. “Still chasing perfection through inbreeding and hacksaw science, Doctor? You know none of these things ever last.”

Varian murmured something in his defence, but Thal had already lost interest. “What’s the progression with Myth?”

“I have taken care of that,” Fane rasped out.

Thal turned, stalking up to him in a blur of motion to stare Fane in his foggy eyes. “**And?**” he hissed, his patience unbelievably thin.

“She will be ours. Alive,” Fane said shakily. “She’s harmonising with Valkyrie as we speak.”

At those words, Thal’s wings unfurled violently, four radiant blades of energy erupting behind him, slicing through the chemical air. Fane flinched away, his chair wheezing with alarmed beeps.

Thal inhaled, composing himself as he slowly retracted them. “Do you know why you’re in that chair?” he asked casually as he resumed pacing.

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Fane said nothing. In an instant, Thal's hand was at the frail man's throat, squeezing just enough to make tubes pop and alarms spike.

Varian appeared beside them, not to help Fane or calm Thal, but to silently monitor the chair's readings, seemingly preoccupied.

Fane croaked, "Because you put me here."

Thal let go, dusting his hand on his cloak. "Exactly." He turned and stalked to the back of the reactor, pacing between rows of failed experiments. Some twitched; others were in stasis, while others darted back and forth, agitated by unknown ailments.

"You forced my hand, Fane. And look what the result is," he said as the doctor glided beside him, hands folded behind his back.

"We both need Myth," Thal continued. "Preferably willing. I can't risk personally interfering anymore. If she remembers just a hint of what we did, she could wipe Titan off the map."

He looked at one massive mutant, the container taking up most of the wall. "I didn't see Valkyrie coming, even though I probably should have," he said, flexing his gloved hands behind his back. "And I can admit, in my current state, I'm no match for her."

He turned to face Varian. "I move that we initiate the first wave."

The doctor's smile was instant, cold and giddy. "Finally!"

Fane was quiet in his seat, however.

"What?" Thal snapped.

"I have someone working on her as well," Fane said uneasily. "She'll come willingly this way."

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Thal laughed dryly. “You mean Ophedius?” he sneered with contempt. “Let the little brat try. But he has some steep competition now.”

He paced back to the control podium, as Varian sealed the corrupted Dregs out of sight once again.

“She was spotted with Valkyrie at the Pulse Duels,” the doctor offered carefully. “Her mutation will be unstable if she continues. Maybe we should—”

“Leave her be,” Thal said with finality. “She needs to believe she’s safe. At this point, any direct interference would prove catastrophic. She can sniff betrayal a mile away.”

He stalked back to Fane, looking the frail man coldly in the eye. “If she even gets a whiff of what we’re doing, we are all good as dead.”

Fane shivered in his seat and said nothing. Thal never had empty words, so he hoped this idiot would take his warning seriously.

Varian, unfettered, pulled a device from his coat and activated the display; an unsettling 3D projection of grotesquely mutated Dreg schematics flickered to life. The models spun slowly, annotated with hastily scrawled AAN-class codes and Varian’s own unsettling nickname for them. The lower tiers were called “Sweetlings”. Towering, warped horrors with spines jutting through armour-skin, and mouths fused open in silent screams that were anything but sweet. Each was tagged with deployment coordinates and containment breach probabilities. A crude, monstrous zoo catalogue.

“The Sweetlings will be first,” Varian said cheerfully, as if presenting a litter of puppies. “Minimal chance of plate, well, and structural damage to Titan itself. We want chaos, not extinction.” He giggled as if it was a joke.

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Fane said nothing, just watched the projection with eager eyes, the thought of mass chaos clearly exciting him.

Thal waved a dismissive hand. “Fine, fine. Make sure they’re unleashed where they won’t cross my path. And keep them off of Apex territory. I don’t want to clean up after you.”

With that, he turned and walked out without so much as a nod of departure. He slammed the door to Dryst’s reactor shut and stalked down the corridor.

Fane won’t let this go. The thought lingered, but he didn’t have time for worry. He launched into the sky, fast and precise, cutting through Titan’s upper atmosphere in a sharp vertical climb.

Minutes later, he dropped like a blade onto the obsidian balcony of the Ash King AI’s tower. The entire spire buzzed with distorted jazz and overlapping AI chatter. Dozens of screens blinked around him, thousands of holo-feeds showing surveillance from the underbelly of Titan, current duel stats, and dozens of illegally catalogued Apex homes.

The Ash King leapt from his charging port, nearly tripping over himself as cables disconnected. His eyes, glowing orange and rigid, dilated instantly and turned a familiar blue. “Commander Voxx! What a pleasure, an honour, a privilege to bask in your glory—”

“Turn it **off**,” Thal growled.

The AI stumbled backward and scrambled to kill the screens. A wave of blessed darkness and silence filled the room.

Thal waited for a moment, choosing his words. “I hear,” he said finally, “there’s news.”

“Ah! Ha! Yes! Yess!” the Ash King stammered. “Valkyrie and Nyx, they were here for a pulse duel. Spectacular, utterly illegal, and glorious. Sadly, Fane got word first, of course, but I was just about to inform Dr. Ekros and—”

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Thal's hand clamped around the AI's throat with speed that defied even its predictive algorithms. The AI spasmed in a glitch burst, his processors panicking.

"I see you know your mistake," Thal said coldly. "So I won't lecture you."

The AI's synthetic hand drifted instinctively toward the plated lower half of his body, a clear twitch of fear shivering through it. Thal had ripped him in half once in a fit of rage, and it seemed the AI didn't want to repeat the experience.

"Tell Ekros. Only Ekros. If you're scared of Fane, you've forgotten who you're really dealing with."

"Of course not, Commander," the AI choked out, static garbling his voice. "Never. Of course. Tell Ekros and only Ekros immediately."

Thal let go, wiping his palm on his cloak as if he'd touched something filthy. "Next time," he said thinly, "they duel until they're flashcracking or at the edge of spinning out. And I will be watching."

He didn't wait for a response, walking to the AI's balcony. His wings extended in one clean snap and he launched into the black night. He had one more stop to make. The Vault. He needed to get there and back before roll call.

The flight was long and cold, the air growing thinner as the old edges of Titan's sky curved into strange gravity pockets. The terrain below became jagged and brutal, almost impossible to traverse by ground. He soared high, his wings slicing clean through the fog that clung to the upper reaches of the Frostline Divide. From this altitude, the Helios region unfurled like a fractured flower on the horizon, surrounded by crystalline forests and flanked by frozen rivers of gas that glittered under the light of Titan's distant sun.

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He angled downward, wings tucked tight, plummeting toward a near-invisible breach in the outer lattice of the Helios Vault. The Vault itself was a strange, complex building, a long forgotten subterranean fortress disguised as an archive. Each wing of the labyrinth housed a specific category: Mutations, Synergy, Bioweapons, Alien Gene Integration, Apex Clones. Few knew its full layout; fewer still knew its depths.

As he descended onto the frost-bitten surface, the ice cracked beneath his feet. A low rumble echoed across the valley. He froze.

Glacier Maws.

The ground pulsed as a massive head broke through the crust, its ringed tusks retracting with a wet hiss. Its translucent belly glowed a pale blue as it detected his heat signature. Thal moved fast, with a flick of his wings, the air distorted behind him. The beast bellowed a freezing vapour, but he was already slicing upward, energy flaring through his limbs as he severed its upper jaw. The creature recoiled with a pained yowl, vanishing back into the tunnels below.

He knew he had to move as he felt another ripple in the snow. He ran as he saw three crystal-wolves breach the river ice to his east. Warm meat was hard to find out here, and he was fresh. He inhaled hard, getting his last few clear breaths even though the air was thinner here. He reached the outer Vault and slammed his palm to the ancient terminal before entering the old AAN access codes through the ancient interface. The door groaned open, and a wave of stale, irradiated air welcomed him.

Inside, everything was cold but dry. The facility ran on one nuclear battery, humming faintly from somewhere deep below. An AI system clicked to life as the door clanged shut behind him. “Welcome Back-k-k-k. Command-d-d-d Au—” It stuttered to a halt, powering down abruptly.

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The lights were dim and sparks dripped from exposed ceiling wires in some places. Burn marks and blast scars painted some of the walls; so much had gone wrong here... He forced himself to concentrate.

He moved quickly to the back and took the creaking elevator down four levels into the classified archive wing. No holograms here, just locked drawers and actual paper. He breathed in the musky scent of old paper and ink, his body still feeling good even with the slight lack of oxygen.

He started searching through the catalogue, his fingers slowly going numb with the cold. Dryst's file was the first he found. It was in a heavy, crude binder, probably built to withstand being around corrosive elements.

He quickly located it on the dusty shelf, opening it quickly to the first yellowed page:

SUBJECT 03B-FSD // DRYST, FANE SOLOMON Class: Mutation-Class E

(Biotoxic Degradation & Partial Catalytic Fluid Absorption)

*Status: **Active** (Bond / Non-Locomotive) Apex BioForge Division / REDACTED*

Black Root Verge Trials

Initial signs of catalytic decay emerged during his 14th birth cycle. Subject demonstrates rare neurological retention while undergoing advanced physical corruption. Emotive cognitions remain absent. Adapted rapidly to controlled environments.

*— **Dr. V. Ekros, Initial Evaluator** — AAN Cycle Year 171.4 Of particular note is the subject's willingness to endure mutations that have destroyed the mind and body of earlier trials. Project approval on the basis of observed self-awareness under duress.*

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— **Dr. Mira Kaen, Mutation Ethics Board** — *AAN Cycle Year 173.2*

Below, hastily scribbled, were notes from what appeared to be personal memos at the bottom of the pages.

STOP letting Fane near the symbiote tanks unsupervised. I don't care what he says! Their mutation rates jump **30%** each time. These are abnormal growth rates with possible parasitic memory encoding!

— *AAN Cycle Year 174.8* **OPHEDIUS, Vexal Incident** – *Cycle Year 275.8:*
Subject Dryst exposed Variant X-Null to bio-corrosive field under forced synergy. The Variant is an adolescent and reacted poorly, experiencing extreme physical and perceived psychological damage. Result: full cascade mutation, uncontrolled phase drift. Variant X-Null to be placed in indefinite black containment. Subject Dryst found with 9% cortical contamination.

Notes: Acceptable Release Risk for Variant X-Null: Dr. V. Ekros.

Thal felt his jaw flex slightly trying to press down unpleasant memories.

As he read further, it seemed like Dryst had requested reintegration into the Variant Research program multiple times, but was denied due to psychological instability. There were several diagnostic scans with the conclusion being he had an emotional obsession with this

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subject. A Blackroot Research Supervisor flagged it, but he didn't recognise the name. Then finally, at the bottom:

Signature Approval: *Dr. Varian Ekros, Senior BioArchitect // Override Tier:*

GRAY-ECLIPSE

He flipped to the attached supplementary profiles, seeing Varian's name on everything. He was like a fungus. A never-dying fungus.

He closed the final page of Fane's record, his stomach slightly unsettled. He had seen Ekros's signature pop up too many times for comfort, too many quiet approvals after years of denials.

He scanned the old physical index at the front, his eyes running down the numbers until he saw: **EKROS, VARIAN.**

He quickly located the physical file, the section labelled "*Personnel — Senior Division.*"

His file was in a sealed black capsule, strange even for this place. He peeled back the magnetic clasp and unfurled the thick, velvety pages. The texture was almost... biological.

He shuddered involuntarily and read:

DR. VARIAN EKROS *Clearance Level: OMEGA-BLACK*

Status: *ACTIVE* – *Departments: Experimental Genetics and Behavioural Mutation Ethics*

INITIAL APPOINTMENT RECORD: *Dr. Ekros was hired under the Directorate of Apex Human Advancements (DAHA) during the final cycle*

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*years of the Terraforming Wars. AAN records birth place: **UNKNOWN**.*

Species: Mostly Human. Modifications: Many.

Note:** “We cannot verify Ekros’s age. All attempts to scan for cortical decay have failed.” — Observer-0B937 Memo: Subject Ethics: **NONE
EXPERIMENTAL INDEX ENTRY #199-F Subject: Variant X-Null
(Ophedius, Vexal)

Subject experienced entropy flux within the brainstem. Modified pain receptors and regenerative failure by design. Theorised pain anchored the mind more effectively than stasis or comfort. Initial results promising. Memory degradation negligible.

EXPERIMENTAL INDEX ENTRY #202-K Subject: M1-X Proto Sample.
DNA exhibits traits from Vault 07 alien strains. Human donor remains unconfirmed. Attempted enhancements exceed protocol. Recommend cryo-suspension and layered false-memory encoding.

Rejected — FSD ATTEMPTS TO REROUTE PROVED FATAL: 3 CLONES
WERE LOST REDACTED REDACTED REDACTED. REDACTED
REDACTED.

Thal gritted his teeth. Ekros had been around for too long; this man was either impossibly old or had cheated mortality. He flipped hastily through the pages and found references to two more projects: one redacted in full, labelled **CATALYST ENGINE—THETA PRIME**, and another marked in Ekros’s own handwriting:

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“Myth is not a result of a mutation.”

There were no further clarifications or added notes. He resisted the urge to fling the file and instead replaced it quickly. He didn't have long, but he needed to make one more detour before he looked for her file, if it was even here. He returned to the front and began flipping through the heavy index, fingers tracing the worn tabs until he found the one marked: **VOXX, T...**

There was no escaping the past now; if he was going to fix the present, he needed to know the past. The past the AAN had tried to bury long ago. His legs moved before he consciously registered it. Down two rows, past a sealed case, and straight to section Omega-Two.

His stomach roiled. The shelves were dust-glazed and dimly lit, but he found what he was looking for quickly. A thick black binder with his name stamped in faint silver on the spine.

He opened it, steeling himself, reading carefully:

**AAN CLASSIFIED PROFILE 02 SUBJECT: THALLION TIMOTHY
VOXX**

***CLASSIFICATION: QUASAR (CONTROLLED CONTAINMENT:
STELLA-TIER)***

Birth Protocol AAN Cycle Year 196.0: — Subject created via artificial fertilisation. Embryonic batch: 11 total viable zygotes from maternal donor (CLASSIFIED: ciera-22) and paternal genetic contribution (CLASSIFIED: RED MERIDIAN PROJECT). Embryo #3 selected based on superior

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energetic response to high-density plasma exposure. Subject incubated externally. Sensory stimulation and physical contact heavily monitored.

Childhood Assessment Notes Summary: *Subject demonstrates exceptional control over reflexes. No emotional baseline. Sterile responses, if any. Recommend introduction of external resonance pairing.*

— *Dr. V. Ekros, Lead Geneticist Resonance Candidate Selected (Half Cycle 208.0): Potential resonance harmonics between Subject VTT and 001X exceed all previous pairing potential. Observable in less than 12 minutes of exposure.*

Request submitted by: *Dr. V. Ekros Committee denied full bonding trials. Cited ethics as well as Subject VTT deemed too unstable. **ALTERNATE MEASURE***

APPROVED: *Controlled Exposure Sessions Observation Log: - Subject 001X provided art supplies and puzzles. Subject VTT chose to observe in near proximity, but doesn't partake. When separation occurred, Subject VTT displayed visible distress. When 001X was returned, Subject VTT normalised.*

— *Training Garden Sessions: - Supervised walks permitted through Helion Prime growth labs. Subject VTT exhibited ability to suppress wing flare-ups when 001X is in close proximity. Continue close monitoring.*

— *Combat Regulation Trials: - Subject VTT placed into wing-expansion testing area. 001X placed behind protective barriers; Subject's aggression lessened significantly in her presence.*

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INCIDENT REPORT (HALF CYCLE 212.6): RESONANCE FAILURE

#731-A LOCATION: CONTAINMENT TO OBSERVATION DECK B-6

— During routine resonance observation, 001X removed from room mid-synergy. Subject VTT entered an uncontrollable state. All methods of suppression failed.

— **TERTIARY MANIFESTATION: HOLY DIVINE TREASURE OF PRIDE, “EGO” - ENGAGED**

— **FIVE CASUALTIES. DOZENS INJURED. SECTOR STERILISED. EMERGENCY REINTRODUCTION OF 001X REQUIRED FOR DEACTIVATION** — After reintroduction, Subject VTT ceased destructive pattern within seconds. Subsequent investigation revealed emotional instability directly tied to prolonged 001X absence.

ISOLATION ORDER (HALF CYCLE 212.6): ENFORCED — Subjects separated indefinitely.

(HALF CYCLE 212.7) - Both subjects exhibited increased trauma indicators. Subject VTT injured via wing overstrain, requiring repeated reintegration with 001X for stabilisation.

Note: Despite 001X's consistent memory erasure and increased permanent memory damage, Subject VTT retains emotional tethering to 001X.

— **Dr. V. Ekros FORCED SYNERGY TRIAL FAILURE:** 001X has suffered catastrophic memory failure. Subject VTT under extreme duress. Full-contact

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resonance initiated. Facility destabilised. Session terminated. Subject 001X removal initiated by 11 AAN overseers.

*— Note: Subject VTT unresponsive. Subject VTT memory alteration incomplete. Subsequent behaviour degraded. Request for 001X reinstatement denied. — Dr. V. Ekros Cross-reference file **M-001X (OBSIDIAN ANNEX LEVEL 7 VAULT CODE 43180346180346)***

As Thal closed the file, he realised his hands were shaking. He couldn't lose control; he felt the paper crease under his fingers. The Vault's oxygen system was degrading, and with the already thin air, he needed to leave. He turned, gritting his teeth, and sprinted out toward the elevator.

The moment Thal broke from the Vault's icy threshold, he launched into the sky with a desperate roar of his wings. The cold air slashed at his face, thin and sharp, his lungs seizing as they strained to pull oxygen from the brittle altitude. Every beat of his wings sent pain surging through his spine, the fractured tendons in the middle pair aching like they'd been torn anew.

He was unravelling. Memories he'd buried like bones beneath Helion's foundations clawed their way up, each one screaming at his mind. Things he'd been forced to forget, things he forced himself to forget.

"Come on, Thallion!" Her laugh rang in his ears as memories washed over him of her dragging him barefoot across the training garden's synthetic moss floor, her little arms hugging a bundle of colour-stained sketchpads. He was her favourite subject, she would joke, as she would have him pose with wings on full display.